

slow, turgid pitches available in Sri Lanka. That the selectors have moved beyond Mohammed Shami reflects the winds of change coursing through India's bowling flank.

In the last four series against the men from the Emerald Isle, India held sway, with the most domineering effort being the 3-0 triumph during the 2017 tour. Yet that chequered past may not have a huge bearing as Gill's troops walk in with their home fortress having been breached twice in the last two years, first by New Zealand and later by

South Africa.

Much would rest on Gill, coping with a niggle, and K.L. Rahul and Yashasvi Jaiswal to keep the batting fires burning. In an era where quelling pace has been seen as a badge of macho honour, the subtle art of countering spin, offering both an obdurate and aggressive bat while revealing nimble footwork, has been on the wane.

Most Indian batters are caught up with international fixtures and the IPL. There is hardly any time to play domestic cricket and finesse their approach against spin. It was a past

luxury that men like V.V.S. Laxman enjoyed as he batted against Venkatapathy Raju and Kanwaljit Singh in the Hyderabad nets.

Siraj and Prasidh Krishna are expected to soften up the Sri Lankan top order, and Kuldeep Yadav and fellow spinners need to be sharp and wily. Veteran Ravindra Jadeja remains a link with the previous tour, having scalped 13 wickets in 2017. Kuldeep had played a lone Test on that visit.

Like New Zealand, Sri Lanka is easy on the eye as a country. And in cricket, like the Black Caps, the



Filling a void: In the absence of Jasprit Bumrah, Mohammed Siraj (left) will lead the Indian attack. R. V. MOORTHY